

SOME J. P. HARRINGTON NOTES ON THE "LONE WOMAN" OF SAN NICOLAS

Edited with Commentary

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THE EXCITEMENT OF DISCOVERY is just as rewarding in ethnography as in archaeology — and particularly so when one is digging through the exhaustive and overwhelming notes of John P. Harrington. The total disorganization of the notes enhances the thrill of discovery, for one never knows what exciting and important piece of information awaits on the next handwritten page.

This recently happened to me as I was poring over Harrington's notes in Boxes 4 and 745 on the Chumash Indians of southern California. Box 4 dealt with Chumash material culture, while Box 745 contained mostly Chumash ritual descriptions. It was quite a surprise to find among these notes material which pertained to the "lone woman"* of San Nicolas Island.

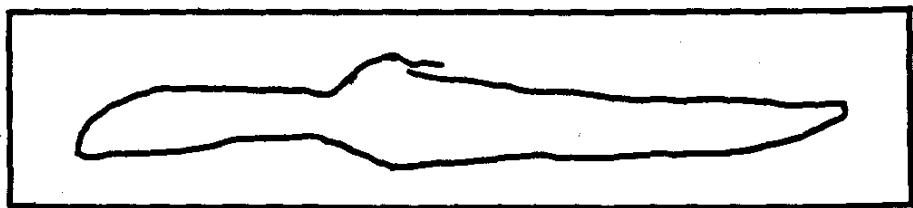
The story of this woman is well known, popularized by the romanticism of a Robinson Crusoe sort of existence (1836?-1853) on a tiny island off the California coast. The important accounts of her story have been collected and published by Heizer and Elsasser (1961);

*Also frequently known as the "Lost Woman" — Ed.

there is no need to repeat them here. Instead, Harrington's material will be presented, supplemented where necessary with end notes.

Bone Knife

The San Nicolas Island woman had a bone knife. It was shaped as shown below.¹



Fernando² does not know what kind of bone the knife was made of. She used it for her defense,³ and not to cut things with.

The Indian woman told Malquiaries⁴ that she was going to her home and would come back,⁵ and they waited and she came back. Hilario Valenzuela,⁶ "the Yaqui", got some trinkets from the woman which he took with him. Fernando never knew what Hilario did with them.⁷

Fernando thinks that the Indian woman of San Nicolas Island was the last one baptized.⁸

A San Nicolas Song

The woman of San Nicolas Island sang this song when they put her dress on her which they had made for her.¹⁰

ih'i^y hiyuhu
 ih'i^y hiyuhu
 hachnuwa la na! na'al
 ih'i^y hiyuhu.¹¹

Although these words are not understood by Fernando, he has sort of an understanding of what they mean: "I continue moving, swaying of the dance, I continue."

Another San Nicolas Song

Nolverto¹² was a Fernandino (Fernandeño) who lived in Santa Barbara, working as a shoe and saddlemaker. He was the only one who could converse with the woman of San Nicolas Island. He conversed with her freely. The Cruzeño Chumash tried, but they could not make her understand.¹³

Fernando does not understand the words in this San Nicolas Island song:

tikitiki
 yahamimina tikitiki
 yahamimina tikitiki
 yahamimina tikitiki
 tikitiki weleleshkima
 nishuyahamimina
 weleleshkima
 nishuyahamimina
 tikitiki.¹⁴

End Notes

1. The drawing is taken from Harrington's sketch of the implement; it is not to scale.

2. This man is Fernando Librado Kitsepawit, one of Harrington's principal Ventureño Chumash informants. Fernando was born about 1804, probably on Santa Cruz Island, and spent most of his adult life in Ventura and Santa Barbara. He died in Santa Barbara on June 19, 1915, at an age of about 111 years (Blackburn 1975:18). Much of Fernando's ethnographic data has been corroborated and used in a number of Chumash studies. These include mythology and stories (Blackburn 1975), history and ritual (Hudson, Blackburn, Curletti and Timbrook 1977), and watercraft, with some plank canoe stories about voyages from San Nicolas Island (Hudson, Timbrook and Rempe 1977). The Chumash called the island Halashat, a Ventureño Chumash word perhaps meaning "victory" (Applegate 1975:28).

3. It is questionable whether the knife was actually intended as a weapon, unless the woman had used it to protect herself from attacks by wild dogs on the island. The Dittman account mentions that the woman did have bone needles and knives, but there are no further details about these objects (Heizer and Elsasser 1961:6).

4. Malquiare's name appears in other Harrington notes on the Chumash. He is described as a Ventureño Chumash man who took part in Chumash rituals. During the brief seven-week period that the woman was alive in Santa Barbara many people came to see her and her possessions (Heizer and Elsasser 1961:11); Malquiare and Hilario Valenzuela.

5. Nidever's account notes that the woman often visited the town (Santa Barbara) from the Nidever house (Heizer and Elsasser 1961:11). "Going to her home" must mean back to the Nidever house. Perhaps she was in town when she met Malquiare and Hilario.

6. Hilario Valenzuela is as yet unidentified; he may have been related to José Valenzuela, husband of Candalaria, one of Harrington's Ventureño informants (Craig 1966:202).

7. Some of the woman's possessions were retained by the Nidevers and other local families, while other items such as a feather dress were reportedly sent to Rome; we have searched for these objects without success.

8. Nidever wrote that Juana Maria was baptized in his house just before death (Heizer and Elsasser 1961:36). Geiger (1965:152) published the data as entry no. 1183, folio 113, of the Register of Burials of the Presidio, recorded by Father González Rubio of Mission Santa Barbara. Ecclesiastical burial was given to Juana Maria, the San Nicolas Island woman, on Oct. 19, 1853, and she received baptism conditionally by Father Sanchez, since there was no one who could understand her language.

9. Harrington recorded this song and the one which follows it in July, 1913; he did not note the informant but it was probably Fernando Librado. For a key to pronunciation see Applegate (1975:23-24).

10. It is not specified which dress elicited the song. According to Dittman and Nidever, on her first visit to their boat anchored off San Nicolas Island the woman was given a homemade dress, which she put on with pride (Heizer and Elsasser 1961:10, 19). If this song was sung then it must have been overheard by one of the Indian crewmen and later repeated to Fernando.

11. The Hardacre account preserved four poorly spelled words in the language of the "lone woman" (Heizer and Elsasser 1961:4-5). These were examined by Kroeber

(1907:153 and note 3) and determined to be Shoshonean, but it could not be stated whether the language was Luiseño, Gabrielino, or different from these. Kroeber added that it was unlikely that her language was understood by any other Indians since she was taken to Santa Barbara, which is located in the territory of non-Shoshonean speaking Chumash Indians, and that there is no evidence that anyone conversant with Luiseño ever interviewed her. The four known words are *nache* for "man", *toygwah* for "sky", *tocah* for "hide", and *puoo-chay* for "body." Harrington's recorded songs expand this number greatly, though without benefit of linguistic analysis we cannot know at this time if the songs are truly Nicoleño, or whether their meanings can be worked out. The implication from the story is, however, that her language was a Gabrielino dialect similar to Fernandino.

Elsewhere among Harrington's extensive notes (in Boxes 2 and 3) are some ethnographic references which pertain to this question, as well as the languages spoken on the other southern channel islands. I have somewhat edited this material so that it can be presented here in Harrington form.

Martin Violin's father was a Santa Catalina Island Indian. He and his brother, both very old, told Martin about the Indians on the islands, and Martin in turn later passed it on to Fernando.

Martin told Fernando that the Fernandinos (Fernandeños) called Santa Barbara Island '*Ichunash*, and that the Gabrielinos also called it by this name. It means "a notice", as for example the blow of a trumpet. [*Ichunash* in Chumash means "whistle" (Hudson, Blackburn, Curletti and Timbrook 1977)]. The Indians on this island were Fernandinos (Fernandeños).

San Clemente Island, according to Martin Violin's father and uncle, was inhabited by a mixture of Gabrielinos and Fernandinos.

The people of San Nicolas Island, an old man said (Martin Violin or his relatives?), came originally from Santa Catalina Island. These people spoke the language of the Gabrielinos.

12. The name Nolverto (also spelled Nolberto) appears occasionally in Harrington's Chumash notes. One note states that Nolverto went with José Polo, alias Poroi,

Manuel Chimuyash, and Manuela Lawi to Monterrey (California?) where they were educated. Later Nolverto returned to Santa Barbara, prior to 1853.

13. Dittman wrote that, as far as he knew, none of the Indians who arrived from various places could converse with the "lone woman"; Nidever and Hardacre also noted that no one could communicate with her (Heizer and Elsasser 1961:11, 21, 35).

14. It is not difficult to conceive of how these songs were recorded. During her stay in Santa Barbara, at the Nidever house, Juana Maria would frequently sing and dance in the presence of visitors (Heizer and Elsasser 1961:11, 21). No doubt Nolverto, and perhaps even Fernando, witnessed such a performance and memorized the song(s).

Acknowledgment

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